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Second Language Acquisition

(ENG504)

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GRAND QUIZ

Grand Quiz #ch 10 to 20

UNIVERSAL GRAMMAR AND FIRST LANGUAGE ACQUISTION

Language is the most abstract piece of knowledge.

UG approach is concerned with knowledge of language called 'competence.

how we access our knowledge base and how it relates to a number of sociolinguistic and psychological variables. Chomsky acknowledges this and has been concerned almost exclusively with addressing the first two issues.

Notion of an innate language faculty in children argues that children go through developmental stages which are very similar across children of given language though progress rate varies. These stages are similar across languages.

Child language is said to be rule-governed

There are many cognitively 'normal' children with impaired language condition known as 'specific language impairment.'

Language and cognition seem to be largely separate but they do interact.

From a theoretical point of view, different possible scenarios are open to consideration; for example,
SL grammars are constrained by universal grammar (UG)
UG does not constrain SL grammar or UG is impaired .

Second language learners are cognitively mature and presumably much more resourceful in problem solving and dealing with abstract concepts.

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UNIVERSAL GRAMMAR AND SECOND LANGUAGE LEARNING

Lenneberg (1967) outlined characteristics that are typically biologically triggered behaviours and argued that language conforms to the criteria used in order to define such behavior. Aitchison presents Lenneberg's criteria as a list of six features:

Direct teaching and intensive practice have relatively little effect.

There is a regular sequence of 'milestones' as the behavior develops; these can usually be correlated with age and other aspects of development.

There may be 'critical period' for the acquisition of the behaviour.

First language learner's initial state is supposed to consist of a set of principles and languages vary in limited ways.

UG is the principle of structure-dependency which states that language critically depends on the structural relationship between elements in a sentence.

All languages are made up of sentences which consist of at least a Noun Phrase and a Verb-Phrase

According to White, there are three potential sources of cross-linguistic variation relating to functional categories.

SL learners are cognitively mature. They already know at least one other language.

Second languages are not constrained by UG principles and parameters, and they do not behave like natural languages.

EVALUATIONS OF UNIVERSAL GRAMMAR AND COGNITIVE

The Universal Grammar (UG) view of language has been very influential since 1950s,

UG approach views language as a mental framework, underlying all human languages. It focuses on some aspects of language and not others. It is only concerned with the sentence and its internal structure rather than any larger unit of language.

It separates language knowledge and language use rigidly.

UG theorists are criticized for lacking in reliability of SL judgments. Therefore, their recent work has used range of elicitation techniques. Furthermore, it has left untouched many central areas to our understanding of SLA process. It is exclusively concerned with documenting and explaining nature of SL linguistic system and ignores the social and psychological variables. UG has been very useful for linguistic analysis. It facilitates well-defined and focused hypotheses;

The Second Language Acquisition (SLA) researcher under these approaches put more emphasis on the learning component of SLL; they are interested in transition theories. Their focus is still very much on the learner as an individual. They are more interested in understanding how the human brain processes and learns new information.

The two approaches of Cognitive theorists of SLA.

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Those who believe that language knowledge might be 'special' in some way,

Constructivists consider that the complexity of language emerges from associative learning processes being exposed to a massive and complex environment.

MODELS OF SECOND LANGUAGE LEARNING

[1]Processing approaches are interested in how brain's processing mechanism deal with second language. These include 1) Information processing approach, 2) Processability theory.

Information processing approach investigates how different memory stores (short-term memory, long-term memory) deal with SL information and how this information is automatized and restructured.
Processability theory looks more specifically at processing demands made by various formal aspects of second language, and implications for learnability and teachability of second language struct

In McLaughlin's model, humans are viewed as autonomous and active.

The mind is viewed as a limited-capacity processor.

Within this framework, second language learning is viewed as acquisition of a complex cognitive skill

Automatization means that learning involves a shift from controlled toward automatic processing via practice. It results in constant restructuring of the linguistic system of SL learner.

When second language learner seems unable to get rid of non-native-like structure despite abundant linguistic input over many years, it is called fossilization.

Anderson's Anderson's Active Control of Thought (ACT*) model is more wide-ranging, and the terminology is different but practice leading to automatization also plays central role. It enables declarative knowledge.

According to Anderson, the move from declarative to procedural knowledge takes place in three stages.

LEARNING STRATEGIES AND SECOND LANGUAGE LEARNING

At the cognitive stage, the learner would learn that an –s must be added to the verb after a third person subject.

At associative stage, learner would work out how to add an –s when the context requires it. In other word, he/she learns to associate an action with corresponding declarative knowledge.
At the autonomous stage learners' action would become increasingly automatic to the point that the declarative knowledge may even be lost.

Some information-processing (I-P) theorists have responded to this problem by suggesting that the 'declarative knowledge' component can be subdivided into conscious and unconscious parts.

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O'Malley and Chamot (1990) suggest that the learning strategies are procedures undertaken by the learners to make their language learning as effective as possible.

Learning strategies can be classified into three categories.

O'Malley and Chamot raised a problem that teaching strategies will involve considerable time and efforts to be effective; therefore, we need long-term studies investigating the effect of strategy teaching.

Towell and Hawkins appeal to an information-processing account

THEORIES OF SECOND LANGUAGE PROCESSING AND CONNECTIONISM

Pienemann believes that language learning is gradual acquisition of computational mechanisms.

The processing challenge within this framework is that learners must learn to exchange grammatical information across elements of a sentence.

Pienemann's Processibility theory explains that SL learners follow a fairly rigid route while acquiring certain grammatical structures.

Outlined by Pienemann, it aims to clarify how learners acquire computational mechanisms that operate on the linguistic knowledge they construct.

The Perceptual Saliency approach argues that human beings perceive and organize information in certain ways, and it is perceptual saliency of linguistic information that drives the learning process forward; rather, than an innate language-specific module.

Slobin (1979) has devised operating principles which guide children in their processing of the linguistic strings which they encounter.

Learning occurs as these patterns become strengthened or weakened through repeated activation or non-activation.
Connectionism is seen as an alternative to symbolic accounts of language acquisition.

EVALUATION OF COGNITIVE APPROACHES AND FUNCTIONAL PERSPECTIVES

Some cognitivists specifically focus the processing mechanisms and how they develop in SLL.

Processing theorists do not say much about language itself.

onnectionist models are often criticized for their clinical and fragmentary view of language ignoring social and linguistic phenomena.

Developmental route of SLL and acquisition of highly complex linguistic phenomena are not yet convincingly explained by these approaches.

Cognitivists primarily investigate development of processing in SL learners.

The ultimate goal of any SLA model is better understanding of SLA process overall.

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Connectionists are primarily concerned with individual.

The researchers who adopt this approach are centrally concerned with the ways in which SL learners set about making meaning and achieving their personal communicative goals.

Functionalism in linguistics is the explication and explanation of grammatical structure in which semantic and pragmatic constructs are integral.

connectionists believe that our mind is predisposed to look for associations between elements and create neural links between them.

They show graceful degradation as do humans with language disorders.

COGNITIVE, TEXTUAL, SOCIAL ORIENTATIONS AND FUNCTIONALISM

Cognitive orientation can be exemplified by the work of Solbin (1985) that proposed the existence of 'basic child grammar' in which children construct their own form-function relationship to reflect a child's-eye view of the world.

textual orientation central issue is to investigate the extent to which particular linguistic devices are employed to organize stretches of discourse intra-sententially as well as across broader stretches of text.

At discourse level, functional linguists are interested in how both vocabulary and grammar are deployed to create textual cohesion across sequences of clauses and sentences.

Functionalist research with social orientation is interested in relationship between the development of child's formal language system and aspects of their social world.

The functional approaches pay attention respectively to the relations between grammatical development and prototype events, between grammar, pragmatics and text organization, and between grammar and the social world.

The functional tradition is well established in SLL theory.

Some adopted a 'patch' approach, studying evolution of forms or development of SL within 'time' or 'space' domain. Whereas others proposed SL 'basic variety' that represents a proto-grammar stage that all learners should pass through.

They have drawn our attention to textual and discourse organization issues, and offered considerable evidence that early learners rely heavily on parataxis rather than on syntax.

A continuing limitation of this approach is that most attention is given to earliest stages of development.

FUNCTIONSLISM AND INTERACTION IN SECOND LANGUAGE LEARNING

Functionalist researchers insist on gradual nature of Inter Language (IL) development and syntacticization but with possible reorganizational consequences.

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At the same time, most functionalists have adopted a 'patch' approach–working on overall utterance structure when studying the basic variety or alternatively exploring development within semantic and formal sub-systems. Functionalists argue for a multi-level approach to analysis.

Functionalist research largely concentrates on analysis of learners' inter-language output and pays relatively less attention to input and even interaction.

These learners are seen more successful in acquiring morphology.

Interactionist' perspective mostly does not challenge the concepts of autonomous language module or cognitive mechanisms at work within the individual learner.

Input hypothesis claims that comprehensive input is the only necessary condition for language learning to take place provided that learner pays attention to it.
It is further directed toward interaction hypothesis and output hypothesis.

The more input is queried, recycled and paraphrased, the greater its potential usefulness as input gets because it should become increasingly well-targeted to particular developmental needs.

Merrill Swain's (1985, 1995) study with immersion students led her to question the claim that comprehensible SL input was sufficient to ensure inter-language development.

So she advanced her claims called 'Output Hypothesis.' Swain argued that students often succeed in comprehending second language (SL) text while only partly processing them. SL production (output) really forces learners to undertake complete grammatical processing. Thus, it drives forward most effectively the development of SL syntax and morphology.

When we examine the role of input and interaction in first language acquisition, we come to know that adults commonly use 'special' speech styles when talking with young children. This is called 'baby talk' which might be helpful to language acquisition.

Noam Chomsky described the notion that aspects of first language acquisition could be related to the input as 'absurd.' In turn, some child language specialists criticized parameter-setting models of acquisition as overly deterministic and ignoring substantial evidence of probabilistic learning from 'noisy' input. Interactionists such as Gallaway and Richard (1994) have pointed out the ways in which CDS might facilitate language acquisition. These include: managing attention, promoting positive affect facilitating segmentation, feedback, correction models, reducing processing load, encouraging conversational participation, and explicit teaching of social routines.

INPUT AND INTERACTION IN SECOND LANGUAGE ACQUISITION

Cross cultural study of child language development supports the idea that children will only learn to talk in an environment which they can make some sense of.

On the other hand, they can learn to talk in a much wider variety of environments (Lieven, 1994).

The normally developing child is well buffered against variation in the input.

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Buffering implies either small amount of social support or any of several different environmental events (Snow, 1994).

Researchers agree that multi-dimensional models of acquisition are necessary, and the way forward in clarifying how input and interaction may be facilitating language acquisition lies at present in close.

Humans acquire language in only one way – by understanding or by receiving 'comprehensive input.' Speaking is a result of acquisition, not its cause.

The concepts of 'understanding' and 'noticing gap' are not clearly operationalized and constantly proposed.

Various studies during 1970s and 1980s demonstrated that the talk addressed to learners was typically grammatically regular but somewhat simplified linguistically.

The degree of simplification reported in many descriptive studies was puzzlingly variable. Also, these studies stopped short at description of distinctive features of ' Foreigner Talk Discourse.

Long proposed a more systematic king features of 'environmental' language, and learners' second language.

Long proposed his Interaction hypo thesis as an extension of Krashe n's original Input hypothesis.

CONSCIOUSNESS RAISING, NEGATIVE FEEDBACK AND NEGATIVE EVIDENCE

Mackey's (1999) study provided the clearest evidence that taking part in interaction can facilitate second language development.

> Earlier interactionist research was criticized for being one-sidedly pre-occupied with functional aspects of SL interaction and neglecting linguistic theory.
> Long's eventual reformulation of interaction hypothesis places more emphasis on linking features of input and the linguistic environment with 'learner-internal factors' and explaining how such linkages may facilitate subsequent language development.
> output hypothesis by Swain (1985, 1995) goes beyond this 'practice' function and proposes three further functions for learner output.

Swain believes that the activity of producing target language may push the learner to become aware of gaps and problems in their current SL system,.

Theorists arguing for a strongly Innatist Model claimed that language is simply not learnable from normal input that provides positive evidence and lacks negative evidence.

We previously saw that negative evidence is much more prevalent in childdirected speech.

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Oliver's (1995) study provides significant findings.
It indicated that more than 60% of the errors by non children receivednative speaker negative feedback from their native speaker partners.

For instance, Lyster and colleagues (1997) noted that recasts were the most common type of feedback.

reported that feedback provided by the teachers varied according to the type of error that had been made. Teachers were more likely to resp ond to lexical errors with negotiation (e.g. clarification requests), whereas they respond to grammatical and phonological errors with recasts.

Best of luck

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